

AI IS ALREADY PART OF YOUR LIFE

Artificial Intelligence in Everyday Life – how smart technology shapes your world • LEVEL A

Have you ever asked your phone a question and it answered you immediately? Or noticed that a website seems to know exactly what you want to buy before you even search for it? If so, you have already experienced **artificial intelligence** — or AI — in action. AI is a type of technology that allows computers to learn from **data** and make decisions in a way that was once only possible for humans. It is not something from science fiction any more. It is already all around you, and it is changing the way we live, study, and work.

But what exactly is AI, and how does it work? At its simplest, AI uses an **algorithm** — a set of rules or instructions — to **process** large amounts of **data** and find patterns. By recognising these patterns, the computer can make predictions or decisions. The more data it processes, the better it gets. So, how much does AI already affect your daily life? Consider these situations:

1 You open a music app and it plays a song you have never heard — but you love it. Why?

a It was just a lucky coincidence — the app picked a random song.

b The app used AI to study your listening habits and recommend something you would like.

2 Your phone unlocks when you look at it. How does it know it is you?

a Someone programmed your exact face into the phone's memory when you bought it.

b The phone uses facial recognition — an AI system that has learned what your face looks like.

If you chose b) for both questions, you are right. These are just two everyday examples of AI at work. People who understand how AI makes these decisions tend to use technology more wisely and carefully. People who do not think about it may not realise how much their choices and **data** are being used — and that can lead to problems.

AI CAN BE HELPFUL ...

- Virtual assistants like Siri or Alexa can answer questions and set reminders instantly.
- **Personalised** recommendations on Netflix or Spotify help you discover things you enjoy.
- AI can **detect** diseases earlier than doctors in some medical tests, saving lives.
- Smart devices **automate** tasks like adjusting heating, saving energy at home.
- AI translates languages in real time, making communication across borders easier.

AI CAN BE HARMFUL ...

- AI systems can contain **bias**, treating some groups of people unfairly without realising it.
- Collecting **data** to train AI raises serious **privacy** concerns for users.
- People may become too **dependent** on AI and lose important skills as a result.
- AI-generated content can be used to spread false information online.
- Governments and companies find it difficult to **regulate** AI fast enough to prevent misuse.

Did you know that AI is **constantly** learning? Every time you click on a video, buy something online, or even pause on a social media post, that action is recorded as **data**. AI systems use this data to build a detailed picture of who you are and what you like. This is why your social media feed often feels like it was made just for you —

because, in a way, it was. The AI has learned to show you content that will keep you engaged for as long as possible.

AI is also being used in ways that go far beyond entertainment. In hospitals, AI can **monitor** patients and **detect** signs of illness that a doctor might miss. In schools, AI tools can personalise learning by identifying which topics a student finds difficult and generating extra practice exercises. In science, AI has helped researchers make important breakthroughs in areas like climate change and medicine that would have taken humans many more years to achieve alone.

So is AI something to be excited about or worried about? The honest answer is both. On one hand, AI has the potential to solve some of the biggest problems in the world — from finding cures for diseases to helping tackle the climate crisis. On the other hand, if we are not careful, AI can also be a **threat** to our **privacy**, our jobs, and even our ability to think for ourselves. The key is not to be afraid of AI, but to understand it. When you know how AI works, you can **interact** with it more thoughtfully and make better decisions about how you use it.

One of the most important things to understand about AI is that it is not neutral. AI systems are built by people, and those people make choices about what **data** to use and how to use it. If the data contains **bias** — for example, if it mostly reflects the experiences of one group of people — then the AI will also be biased. This is why it is so important for AI systems to be **transparent**: users should be able to understand how decisions are being made, and companies should be held responsible when things go wrong.

The good news is that you do not need to be a computer scientist to use AI wisely. You just need to stay curious, ask questions, and think critically about the technology around you. AI is one of the most powerful tools ever created — and like any tool, what matters most is how we choose to use it.

ACTIVITIES

3

Read the article again and answer the questions. Write *True* or *False*.

- 1 AI is only used in science fiction films, not in real life.
- 2 An algorithm is a set of rules a computer follows to make decisions.
- 3 The more data an AI processes, the better it usually gets.
- 4 AI can only be used in entertainment, like music and video apps.
- 5 AI systems can sometimes be biased if the data they use is unbalanced.
- 6 You need to be a computer scientist to use AI in a thoughtful way.

4

Match the highlighted words and phrases in the article to the meanings.

- 1 a set of rules a computer follows to complete a task
- 2 made especially for one person based on their interests
- 3 information collected and used by computers
- 4 to find or notice something that is not easy to see
- 5 open and easy to understand; not hidden
- 6 a suggestion for something you might like or want

5

Read the extension section of the article and answer these questions.

- 1 Give one way that AI could help solve a global problem.
- 2 What does the article say could happen if AI is not used carefully?
- 3 Why is it a problem if the data used to train AI contains bias?
- 4 What does the article say is the most important thing to understand about AI?

6

Think about AI in your own life. Write 4–6 sentences using ideas from the article.

Use these phrases to help you:

I use AI when I ... / One thing I didn't know about AI is ... / I think AI is ... because ...

■ TALKING POINTS

Can you think of three ways you used AI today without realising it?

Do you think AI will replace teachers one day? Why or why not?

Should companies be allowed to collect your data to train their AI? Is it fair?

Would you rather have a doctor or an AI diagnose an illness? Give reasons.